City Group Guide

For City Group leaders and hosts

THANK YOU FOR LEADING

> Thank you for opening your life to others. A City Group grows through small, faithful things: remembering a name, pulling up another chair, opening Scripture, praying honestly, checking in during the week. You don't need a perfect evening or an answer to every question, and you don't lead alone. Policies live in one place, the GCC Group Leader Agreement. This guide covers the rest.

IN THE CITY, FOR THE CITY

Golden City Church's vision is to see the city fully following Jesus. City Groups carry that vision into our neighborhoods. We gather *in the city*, sharing life where people already live, and *for the city*, so that what takes root in the group shapes how we love and serve our neighbors.

WHAT A CITY GROUP IS AND ISN'T

A City Group is life together centered on Jesus. People make friends, pray, care for one another, open Scripture, and practice following Jesus together. Someone with questions, a hard week, or little church background should still find room to take part.

- It doesn't have to be an in-depth Bible study. Scripture has a real place, but a group isn't a class.
- It is more than friends spending time together. A Golden City group gathers with a purpose.
- It supports Sunday worship and the church's pastoral care. It doesn't replace them.
- You are a leader and companion in following Jesus. You are not anyone's counselor or only source of help.

Within that, you design your group: weekly or every other week, the day, the time, and the material. Spend the first few gatherings mostly getting to know the people who joined.

THREE CORE ELEMENTS

Every Golden City group keeps community, prayer, and Scripture together.

- **Community:** learn names, welcome newcomers, make room for quieter voices, and notice who needs a check-in.
- **Scripture:** read God's Word together and ask what it shows us about God and how we respond to Christ.
- **Prayer:** bring real life to God and pray for one another. No one has to pray aloud.

If your group meets on a walk or while serving, plan where Scripture and prayer will fit.

BELONGING, BEHOLDING, BECOMING

Belonging is being welcomed into relationship with God and his people. **Beholding** is attending to Jesus through Scripture, prayer, worship, and dependence on the Holy Spirit. **Becoming** is growing into his likeness in everyday obedience, love, service, and witness. People don't pass through these in order; each one feeds the others.

Russ asks every leader: **"What happens in your group that causes spiritual transformation?"** Take that

question to prayer as you prepare. We can't make the Spirit move, but we can make room for people to meet Christ, respond to his Word, and care for one another.

CHOOSING YOUR MATERIAL

You choose what your group goes through: the Weekly Recap, a book of the Bible, a Christian book, a devotional, or something else. Choose on purpose, for what will help these people grow in Christ this season. Before your group starts, list your choice on the group profile form. The ministry reviews it so the ministry directors know what each group is studying and can support you, and the choice stays yours. If you're unsure whether something fits, ask Paul.

A TYPICAL GATHERING

Adapt these to your people, your place, and your time.

1. **Welcome and connect.** Catch up and introduce newcomers. Food helps when you can manage it, but it isn't required.
2. **Open Scripture.** Read together. With the Weekly Recap, give enough background for someone who missed Sunday.
3. **Discuss.** Ask a few open questions and help people see a faithful next step.
4. **Pray.** Protect time for it instead of leaving it to the last few minutes.
5. **Follow up.** Confirm the next gathering and notice who needs a check-in.

You don't have to finish every question. Afterward, ask yourself whether people had room to belong, whether you attended to Christ in Scripture and prayer, and who needs care this week.

STEERING THE CONVERSATION

When a tangent crowds others out, try "Thanks for sharing that. Let's hear from someone else," or "Let's bring that back to the passage. What do you notice here?" Ask the room instead of one person, and let people pass. If one person keeps taking all the space, talk with them kindly afterward (Policy 9). When you don't know an answer, say so, and bring disputed teaching to Paul or Russ (Policy 11).

When someone shares something painful, stop and care; the study can wait. Listen before you try to fix anything, offer to pray, and don't press for details or promise secrecy. Follow up privately and help them reach pastoral support (Policy 7).

BOUNDARIES AND PACE

Read the GCC Group Leader Agreement and sign its Leader Acknowledgement. It covers confidentiality, prayer requests, children, homes, alcohol, money, conflict, and conduct.

- Your meeting address can go on your Planning Center group profile, which only group members see. Send other personal details by email or your Church Center group chat, never publicly.
- Ask before you share someone's story or prayer request (Policies 5 and 6).
- Use email for updates so people without the Church Center app aren't missed, and give early notice when plans change.
- Let members help with welcome, meals, and care. Tell Paul when your capacity changes; you can step back for a season without shame. Small numbers or uneven attendance don't disqualify you as a leader or take anything from your faithful service.

YOUR SUPPORT SYSTEM

- **Paul**, Ministry Director for Groups and Classes, is your first call for questions about your group, your material, or your own capacity. Book one-on-one time through his sign-up calendar.

- **Group Leader Collaboration** brings current leaders together on the first and third Saturday mornings of each month. Most leaders serve in their own homes on their own nights and rarely see another leader at work. At Collaboration you share what's working and what's hard, learn from each other, and come away encouraged and better equipped. Paul posts times and places in the leaders' Church Center group chat.
- **Russ and the pastoral team** step in when care goes beyond what the group can give.
- **The Groups resources page** has the Weekly Recaps and the agreement.

WHEN YOU NEED HELP

In an emergency, call 911 first. Then tell Russ Daly, Lead Pastor and primary pastoral contact, the same day, or Paul as backup if you can't reach Russ. You'll receive their numbers privately. Don't investigate or carry a serious situation alone. The GCC Group Leader Agreement gives the full response for each case below.

IF…	FIRST STEP	AGREEMENT
Someone's life or safety is in immediate danger	Call 911	Policy 1
You suspect abuse or neglect of a child or vulnerable adult	Don't investigate or promise secrecy; tell Russ the same day	Policy 2
Someone speaks of suicide or self-harm	Stay with them; share 988; tell Russ the same day	Policy 3
Someone discloses violence or abuse at home	Put their safety first; tell Russ the same day	Policy 4
Grief, illness, or a struggle bigger than the group	Pray, stay close, and refer them to a pastor	Policy 7
Someone asks for money	Listen with care and refer them to Russ	Policy 8
Ongoing disruption or conflict	Talk privately; bring in Paul	Policies 9 and 10

Telling the church never replaces a report the law requires (Policy 2).

KEEP THESE CLOSE

- GCC Group Leader Agreement: policies, emergency responses, and pastoral contacts.
- resources.goldencity.church: Weekly Recaps and other Groups resources.